

50 STATES: Pennsylvania

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Last Updated: 2:52 PM, September 22, 2009

Posted: 12:00 AM, July 14, 2009

ALONG the Allegheny River in Pittsburgh, the mills, foundries and factories that once produced iron, glass and aluminum now house sleek, artsy lofts. Technology and pharmaceutical firms have replaced the city's obsolete steel industry. Boutiques and restaurants have sprung up along streets in once-dying neighborhoods. Where once there were choking fumes from coke works, today there's the smell of roasting organic coffee.

Pittsburgh is looking pretty good.

In fact, compared to other fading rust-belt cities like Detroit and Cleveland, Pittsburgh is looking great.

Though the city's population has declined dramatically from a high of 677,000 in 1950 (to about half that today), it's been holding fairly steady since 2007 (and well ahead of the huge exodus in the '70s and '80s after the mills closed).

Unlike much of the country, the housing market here is stable. Development has surged along the waterfront, successfully luring people downtown into new condos and office buildings, as well as to the stadiums of the Super Bowl-winning Steelers (and the not-so-winning baseball team, the Pirates). Miles of biking and walking trails have been constructed along its riverfront.

But much of the city's revitalization can be traced to the smaller-scale efforts taking place in its 90 ethnically diverse neighborhoods (and in its surrounding small towns). Residents, community leaders and small-business owners have recognized the importance of maintaining, and in some cases, rescuing, their communities. Some are choosing to hang on to the last vestiges of authenticity. Some are maintaining and refurbishing what's already there. Others are welcoming newcomers while still working to keep things local. Still others are undergoing full-scale gentrification.

Take East Liberty, which in the 1950s was a playground for wealthy folks with names like Mellon and Westinghouse, but by the '70s was in serious decline. Today, big-box stores such as Whole Foods and Home Depot have moved in, while the nabe's commercial center is slowly being rehabilitated.

Among the neighborhood's more successful projects is the renovation of the ornate, 1919 Regent Theatre, renamed the Kelly-Strayhorn Theater in honor of two former East Liberty residents, Gene Kelly and Billy Strayhorn. Until last year, it had been a rental facility, but its new executive director, Janera Solomon, has started to present original programming that's "reflective of the neighborhood's diversity," she says. "For example, our contemporary dance festival had a mix of jazz, hip-hop and ballet artists."

Solomon has seen the changes in East Liberty over the past few years.

"More people are paying attention to the neighborhood, but the seeds of it have always been here," she says. "Like the Shadow Lounge, where people started off there at open-mike nights and now are performing on our stage."

A cursory glance at the schedule at the Shadow Lounge (a block from the theater) shows just about every genre represented: poetry nights, comedy shows, DJs, live jazz and singer-songwriters. Local artwork hangs on the walls, and books, alt-zines and board games are scattered among the boho coffee- and wine-sipping crowd.

Just up the street is Kelly's Bar & Lounge, which attracts the hipster set, even though the place has been around for over 100 years. Cocktails here are mixed under the auspices of LUPEC (Ladies United for the Preservation of Endangered Cocktails), which means that the female bartenders are experts at concocting the classics, like a Sidecar or a Manhattan (\$6 each). They're the perfect complement to the retro décor and quirky jukebox stocked with Patsy Cline, Johnny Cash and the Pixies.

In the nearby Italian neighborhood of Bloomfield, things look much as they did generations ago. Well, except for that huge sign welcoming you to "Pittsburgh's Little Italy" and the red, white and green parking meters along its main street, Liberty Avenue. But that's about as touristy as it gets. Unlike New York's Little Italy, Italians still live, work, eat and shop here as they have since the 1900s. Widows dressed in head-to-toe black slowly stroll the narrow alleys lined with modest rowhouses decorated with Virgin Marys. Numbers are still booked on the corner. Most of the restaurants serve Italian cuisine.

And you can still find real, homemade sopressata.

"Almost nobody makes it anymore, it's too time-consuming," says the counterman at Groceria Italiana on Cedarville Street,

cutting thick slices of the oily, peppery salami. Groceria Italiana is one of two remaining neighborhood markets that still produce and sell Italian delicacies like stuffed eggplant and 14 kinds of ravioli, along with bread from the nearby Sanchiolo Brothers Bakery. On nearby Liberty Avenue, the larger Donatelli's Italian Food Center stocks just about everything you could ever need to open an Italian restaurant: huge cans of San Marzano tomatoes, gallons of extra-virgin olive oil and shelves upon shelves of jarred anchovies, capers and vinegars.

But Bloomfield isn't a time capsule. Though the façade of the historic Plaza Theatre on Liberty looks authentic, its marquee announces a Starbucks and a sub shop — films are no longer shown there.

No place quite sums up the spirit of Pittsburgh like Millvale, a mile-long town whose business-district sign reads "Bridging Yesterday and Today." This Mayberry-like borough, not far from downtown, has hung on despite the closing of its steel mills, breweries and saw-blade factory (you can still glimpse "SAW" painted on the red brick façade), as well as the floods that regularly plague the low-lying town.

As for the "yesterday" part, there's the P&G Diner (part of Pittsburgh's Pamela's chain), set inside the still-functioning Lincoln Pharmacy on North Avenue. Locals line up for the above-average diner food and bygone soda-fountain atmosphere. For the "today," you need to go no farther than across the street, to Jean-Marc Chatellier's Bakery. Opened in 1992, the tiny shop has brought European flair to this working-class town. Brioche, croissants and strudel share counter space with elegantly crafted cakes and tarts, baskets of freshly baked baguettes line one wall, French-language magazines are scattered about. The chef's Breton Cake, a rich shortbread dessert, is usually gone by mid-morning.

Bridging the two worlds is the Attic Record Store on Grant Avenue. Albums, 45s and CDs of all genres — jazz, punk, soul, doo-wop, metal, reggae — are wedged into every nook and cranny; autographed photos of musicians take up every inch of wall space. No matter how obscure the recording, you'll likely find it here (like a 78-inch of "The Visiting Nurse Service of New York" from 1960).

The heavily Catholic town now numbers just 4,000, so Millvale deconsecrated one of its many churches. Today, Lincoln Avenue's St. Ann's church compound is now Mr. Smalls Funhouse. This 650-person concert venue and recording studio hosts local and national acts, including Ryan Adams, Fall Out Boy and Broken Social Scene.

5 MORE GREAT PITTSBURGH NEIGHBORHOODS

1) REGENT SQUARE

After an afternoon of bike-riding or Frisbee-throwing at the 600-acre Frick Park, folks head to the 3½-block main drag of nearby Regent Square for a bit of relaxation — and a beer or two. True beer aficionados make their way to D's Six-Pax & Dogz Shoppe for its "Beer Cave," where you can choose from more than 900 (!) bottled beers from just about every country (1118 S. Braddock Ave., [412] 241-4666). More refined palates should reserve a spot at Legume, a petite, family-run bistro that serves up French, American and Italian fare. Much of the food is sourced locally and the menu changes daily (it's posted online at legumbistro.com by 5 p.m.). Thursdays feature a special local meat-tasting menu (three courses for \$29), but vegetarians have plenty of options here, too, including a three-course vegetarian dinner on Wednesdays. The restaurant is BYOB with a \$3 corkage fee (1113 S. Braddock Ave., [412] 371-1815).

2) HIGHLAND PARK

There's the namesake 380-acre park and Pittsburgh Zoo and PPG Aquarium but otherwise, the mainly residential enclave of Highland Park keeps a pretty low profile. But it does boast one of the city's best coffee spots, Enrico's Tazza d'Oro, where locals line up for lattes and excellent pastries, including sfogliatelle, stuffed with citrus-tinged ricotta (1125 N. Highland Ave., [412] 362-3676). Highland Park's dining options are few and far between. Fortunately, Joseph Tambellini decided to open his restaurant (eponymously named) here, in a three-story, white-brick former residence (5701 Bryant St., [412] 665-9000). Tambellini isn't a trained chef; he picked up his kitchen skills from his family, starting as a teen at his father's downtown Pittsburgh restaurant, Robert Tambellini's, and later working at his uncle's place, Tambellini's. Here, the young chef updates Italian favorites like veal marsala and osso buco, but still manages to keep the local blue-haired clientele (many of whom are Italian) happy. Pastas are delish, but be sure to request an (off-the-menu) order of meatballs.

3) SOUTH SIDE FLATS

Pittsburgh's version of the East Village, South Side Flats, is one of the hippest parts of town, filled with young residents who take advantage of the buzzing nightlife along East Carson Street (also, you will probably be told, America's longest business Victorian National Historic District). Most bars are beer-oriented, but if it's a decent glass of wine you're after, head off the main drag to Dish Osteria (128 S. 17th St., [412] 390-2012), then dine at the charming, two-story French-American bistro Le Pommier (2104 E. Carson St., [412] 431-1901).

4) LAWRENCEVILLE

Lined with groovy independent boutiques, galleries and design shops, this is the place to get your style on in Pittsburgh. Check out Pavement for great shoes (3629 Butler St., [412] 621-6400); Elements for vintage and retro clothing (3816 Butler St., [412] 681-7627); and stop in for woodburning-oven pizza at Piccolo Forno (3801 Butler St., [412] 622-0111).

Arsenal Bowl is a must-see for old-school bowling and music. Try it on a Friday night for a live DJ and karaoke, along with an all-you-can-bowl deal for just \$9.95 until 2 a.m. (212 44th St., [412] 683-5992). At Your Inner Vagabond, you can grab a coffee, buy art or lounge around in the harem-like décor--you might stumble upon a West African drumming workshop or belly-dancing classes (4130 Butler St., [412] 683-1623).

5) SHADYSIDE

Here's where the upper crust live and shop, so expect snazzy, high-end boutiques, antiques stores and art galleries along its two main arteries, Walnut Street and Ellsworth Avenue. On the corner of Walnut and South Aiken Avenue is Schiller's Pharmacy, a 105-year-old drugstore that stocks luxury lotions and potions by the likes of Klorane and Thymes ([800] 491-0072). The independently owned clothing boutique E.B. Pepper has been a favorite for mother/daughter shopping for the past 30 years (5411 Walnut St., [412] 683-3815) and the nearby Prantl's Bakery is (rightfully) famous for its burnt-almond torte (5525 Walnut St., [412] 621-2092). At La Feria, you can dine on South American fare amongst handmade Peruvian crafts for sale (5527 Walnut St., [412] 682-4501). On the less-trafficked Ellsworth Avenue, get measured for a custom-made dress at Diana Misetic, a Croatian designer whose frocks are favored by Pittsburgh society (5896 Ellsworth Ave., [412] 363-6442), or head to Hiptique for chic, affordable apparel (5817 Ellsworth Ave., [412] 361-5817).

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